consciousness. So differences are not ultimate realities. Finite individuals are subject to a basically distorted worldview that conceals the reality by superimposing diversity upon it. A force called 'beginningless misconception' (***avidya***) is responsible for the appearance of differences between selves, cognitions and objects. ***Avidya*** is connected with sorrow, delusion and passion. It conceals one's true nature, creating the illusion that one is an individual agent, which is the root cause of rebirth.

The relationship between ***Brahman*** and ***avidya*** is indefinable as real or unreal (*anirvacaniya*). Were ***avidya*** the same as ***Brahman***, release would be impossible. If it is a positive entity (***bhava-rupa-avidya***) independent of ***Brahman***, non-dualism is contradicted. Were it absolutely non-existent, there would be neither bondage nor worldly transactions (***vyavahara***).

Scripture is the authoritative source of knowledge (***pramana***) about the absolute reality that is already implicit in every preconceptual awareness. Negative scriptural statements teach the unreality of phenomenal diversity and eradicate ***avidya*** while positive ones affirm the sole reality of ***Brahman*** with which the soul (***atman***) is identical.

While the *Advaita* theorist ***Shankara*** thinks that the *Vedic* ritual actions are dispensable in the quest for liberation, Mandana's view is that all *Vedically* enjoined action is purificatory and predisposes towards realisation of one's true identity. He holds that release from rebirth requires a combination of knowledge and ritual action (*jnana-karma-samuccaya-vada*), a way especially suited to householders in normal society. Renunciation of all ritual actions (***samnyasa***) is a possible path to self-realisation but it is difficult. It is better that the knowledge gained from the scriptural texts teaching the identity of the soul and ***Brahman*** be intensified by the performance of ritual actions and contemplation.